

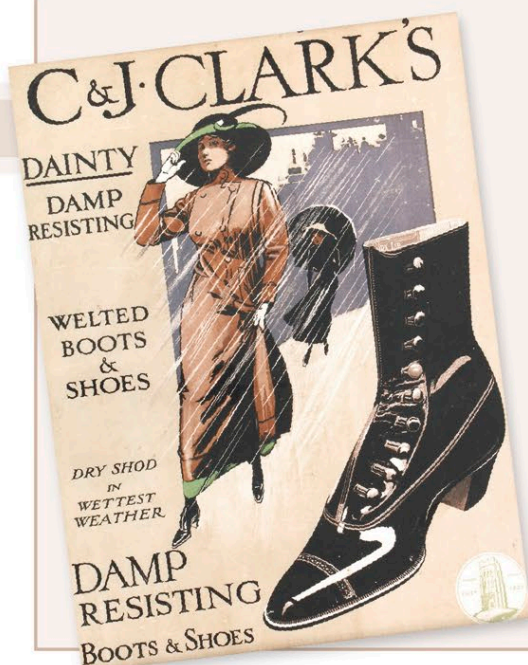
1914–1918

WARTIME WOMEN

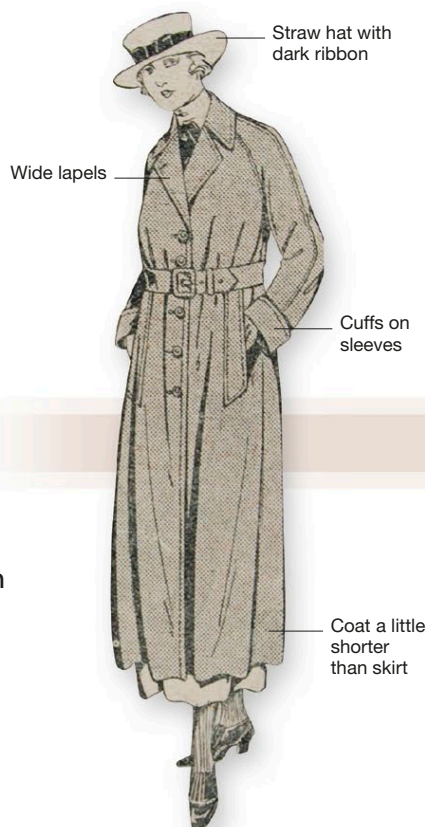
World War I accelerated the trend towards less restrictive and decorative daywear as many women became accustomed to wearing practical uniforms or workwear. The loss of male workers to the armed forces meant that women were employed as railway porters, tram drivers, bus conductors, window cleaners, and even welders. Women also became members of voluntary forces, which were organized and dressed along military lines, such as the “land girls” who worked in agriculture or helped with cutting timber. Most of these occupations came with their own uniforms, though these often had to be bought. Some garments, such as the “British Warm” greatcoat worn by officers during World War I, was adopted as fashionable wear by both men and women.

FOOTWEAR

The war had a big impact on fashion, changing the way women perceived themselves and how they were seen by others. Many more women were now doing manual work, requiring practical, hardwearing clothing such as trousers and sturdy, sensible footwear. Women needed shoes and boots that were comfortable enough to wear all day, and strong enough to withstand the elements. British shoemakers Clarks produced boots that were waterproof as well as “dainty”. The low heel and welting made them practical, while their narrow fit and neat eyelet fastenings kept them feminine.



Advertisement for women's boots, 1913



Trenchcoat Versions of the belted officer's coat became part of many women's uniforms. For motoring, or as part of the workwear of the “land girls”, the coat was shortened to just above the knee.



Red Cross This American woman's Red Cross Motor Services uniform consists of a double-breasted and belted overcoat, breeches, and a cap with an emblem badge. It was worn with leather boots and gloves.



Russian look The revival of the full skirt at the end of 1914 pleased petticoat makers. Russian influences remained and knee-length tunics as well as fur-trimmed “Cossack” coats were “quite the smart thing” for women outside the workplace.



Land Army Wearing hardwearing jodhpurs and sturdy boots, this member of the British Women's Land Army is one of about 33,000 females who worked on the land during the war, all requiring practical and durable garments.